

Mission Basundhara is the beginning of a continued exercise guided by Prime Minister Narendra Modi's vision of an India, where citizens can hold the administration accountable for every service they are entitled to."

Dr Himanta Biswa Sarma
Chief Minister, Assam

especially the poor and disadvantaged ones, have lost grip over land in the state as they fail to access land records in government offices. Their ancestral lands have been taken away by the illegal immigrants who often forge documents with the help of middlemen.

Chief minister Sarma's intent of cleaning up the entire process was evident from the very first day. During a sudden operation in September 2021, nearly 700 land brokers and middlemen were arrested across the state. "We wanted to send a message that we mean business and here is a government, which stands by the common men and women," says Sarma. But he knew that such one-time action would not be enough to bring a permanent solution to people's problems related to land records and transactions.

This larger objective resulted in the introduction of Mission Basundhara, a brainchild of Sarma and the most impactful public initiative of Assam government. Launched by the chief minister on October 2, 2021, this mission was a decisive step towards streamlining land revenue services and records, facilitating easy access to the public for their land-related work, reducing the pendency in update of land records and eliminating middle men from the land management ecosystem. "The mission aims to eliminate the middleman from the system and reduce unnecessary visits to government offices, while empowering the public to resolve land-related issues online in a hassle-free manner," says Sarma.

Though land records were digitised in Assam over a decade ago, there was a considerable need to digitally transform the mode of availing land related services so that ordinary citizens could easily access those. Also, the characteristics of a land parcel have changed drastically over the years. The changes happen because of various reasons such as transfer in ownership, change in land use, partitions, erosion, government land leases and acquisition of land. But these changes were yet to be documented in the land records and maps.

Mission Basundhara was thus designed with three core components—updating of land records through a one-stop interface, survey of 1,251 non-cadastral villages (where no survey has been conducted) and re-survey of 1,122 cadastral villages to create integrated and real-time land records and maps.

The first phase of the mission commenced on October 2, 2021, with the opening of the application window and concluded on May 8, 2022, with the disposal of all applications received. Between October 2, 2021, and December 7, 2021—the time window given to file applications—8,13,891 applications were received on pending matters related to land records. These were settled by May 8, 2022, the deadline set for resolution of these cases.

In the first phase, the transparent, contactless Mission Basundhara portal, supported by Integrated Land Records Management System (ILRMS)—the integrated software for disposing cases—provided 10 land revenue services. The applications received and service wise disposal of cases were monitored through the dashboard incorporated in the portal. Applicants could track

WHAT MISSION BASUNDHARA ACHIEVED

1. For the first time, land-related services application and delivery made online
2. Automation of services reduced visits by citizens to revenue offices
3. Online applications received from 14,084 villages through 2,75,160 mobile numbers; 8,13,981 applications disposed in 150 days

UPCOMING NEW INITIATIVES

Title Guarantee Bill; restructuring of survey architecture; restructuring of lots, land acquisition portal, digitizing re-settlement circles, popularizing digital stamping, National Generic Document Registration System, automation of zonal valuation, optimization of land classes and land rent, augmentation of revenue generation

